

ARMS AND THE MAN: Dutt's appeal in the Supreme Court can also boomerang

IN THE MAKING

Banking on a Fallen Star

Sanjay Dutt's six-year imprisonment is not good news for film producers and directors. Trade analyst Komal Nahta says Rs 50-60 crore is currently riding on him. Only two of the projects in Dutt's kitty—the Inder Kumar-directed *Dhamaal* and *Dus Kahaniyan*, produced by his and Sanjay Gupta's company White Feather Films—are now complete, with *Dhamaal* slated for release on September 7. The money on hold includes three of Dutt's incomplete films—*Alibaug*, again directed by Gupta, on which shooting began only recently, the Sanjay Gadhvi-directed *Kidnap* and Abbas-Mustan's *Mr Fraud*. When contacted about the status of *Alibaug*, Gupta said, "I don't want to talk about it right now."

Another production house that stands to lose from Dutt's sentence is Shree Ashtavinayak Vision. The company is working on *Kidnap* and *Mr Fraud*, which were both slated to be released in 2008. A source from the production house said that shooting for both the films, being made on a budget of about Rs 38-40 crore each, has not yet been completed. "We've shot about half of *Mr Fraud* and 60 per cent of *Kidnap*," said the source, while refusing to comment on how the films will be affected by Dutt's imprisonment.

Others are optimistic. Shakeel Noorani, who is producing and directing the Dutt-starrer *Jaan Ki Baazi*, has finished 50 per cent of the shooting and says there is no reason to panic. "We will wait for his Supreme Court appeal," he says. The film is being made on a budget of Rs 12 crore and was to be released early next year. Other projects starring Dutt that have been announced but not kickstarted include Rajkumar Hirani's third offering in the Munnabhai series tentatively titled *Munnabhai Chale Amreeka*. The film is still in the scripting stage and shooting has not begun. Dutt was also slated to act in his home production *Beehad* and Sujoy Ghosh's fantasy film *Aladin and the Mystery of the Lamp*, but as is the case with Hirani's project, Dutt hasn't started shooting for these two either.

by Jhimli Motihar

Rs 50,000 was the average annual cost of trial for an accused

Over 50 lawyers appeared in the trial

"The accused is entitled to sympathy, but not in determining the sentence. Owning a pistol was eminently dangerous. The arguments sound attractive but don't stand to reason. For every citizen, the nation must come first and he must respect the laws of the land. If you can't, then you cannot be upheld as a moral person."

Kode has also assessed Dutt on the basis of his conduct with the co-accused, Yusuf Nulwala, Kersi Adajania

and Rusi Mulla. After Dutt discovered that Magnum Videos' Samir Hingora and Hanif Kadawala had been arrested in connection with the bomb blasts, he called Nulwala and asked him to destroy the weapons. "He advocated others to commit a crime, which is a very serious offence," Kode surmised. Nulwala picked up the arms from Dutt's Bandra residence and took them to Adajania, who owned a fabrication unit, and melted the AK-56 with a gas cutter. The duo agreed to deal with the pistol the next day. Since Adajania had to go to Kolkata the next day, he left the pistol with his friend Mulla. The court acknowledged that Mulla knew nothing about the conspiracy, and when

Adajania failed to pick up the pistol after nine days, Mulla gave it to Ajay Marwah. Said Kode: "He was deceived by a friend and got embroiled in the case due to him."

The judgement has come as a shock not just to Dutt's family, but to the entire film industry. His directors and co-stars alike believe that he has been given a very harsh sentence. Says Mahesh Bhatt, director and a close family friend of the Dutt, "I cannot say if the sentence is too harsh because Justice Kode has been strict with all his punishments. When I look at Sanju along with all the others, I feel that the sentence hasn't been harsh. But when I separate him from them I do feel that

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